

Session 1: Exodus and the Exodus

Key Takeaways

- The exodus event establishes and helps define the identity of the community.
- Pay attention to who is named and who is not. The biblical authors illustrate the priorities of the text with details like these.
- Moses' deliverance and commissioning sets the pattern for later events in the book.

Did the Events in Exodus Really Happen?

"As a constitutive event, the exodus is recognized as an event of such import that the community would not be what it is without its having occurred."

Fretheim, Terence (2010). [*Exodus \(Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching\)*](#). Westminster John Knox Press.

See: [Deuteronomy 26:1-9](#); [Joshua 24:1-28](#); [Isaiah 43:14-21](#); [Psalm 105](#)

When Did the Exodus Happen?

A summary of Nahum Sarna's *Exodus* from the Jewish Publication Society.

15th Century

The argument for dating the exodus to the 15th century is largely based on 1 Kings 6:1, which counts 480 years from the exodus to Solomon's reign. Major challenges to this date arise in that Pharaoh lived at Thebes during that time, 400 miles away, and controlled Canaan.

Perhaps this number is somewhat symbolic, representing 12 generations at 40 years per generation, when in reality the number is considerably smaller.

13th Century

Based on the location of the storage cities being built in [Exodus 1:11](#), some date the exodus to the 13th century when Pharaoh lived near Pithom and Rameses. At this time, Egypt had lost control of Canaan, and the archaeological record attests to the existence of "Israel" as mentioned on Pharaoh Merneptah's Stele (c.1224-11).

But what about the 480 years? Furthermore, geography and archaeology of the conquest don't match exactly.

Which Pharaoh?

He is unnamed in the text, but pay close attention to whose names we learn.

Note: The mention of Pithom and Rameses in Exod. 1:11 does not solve this, since a scribe could have updated the city names later.

Literary Design of Exodus

Exodus 1-4: The Saga of Moses

1-2: Moses delivered from pharaoh

3-4: Moses commissioned by YHWH

Exodus 5-40: The Saga of the Hebrews

5-18: Hebrews delivered from Pharaoh

5-11: Ten plagues

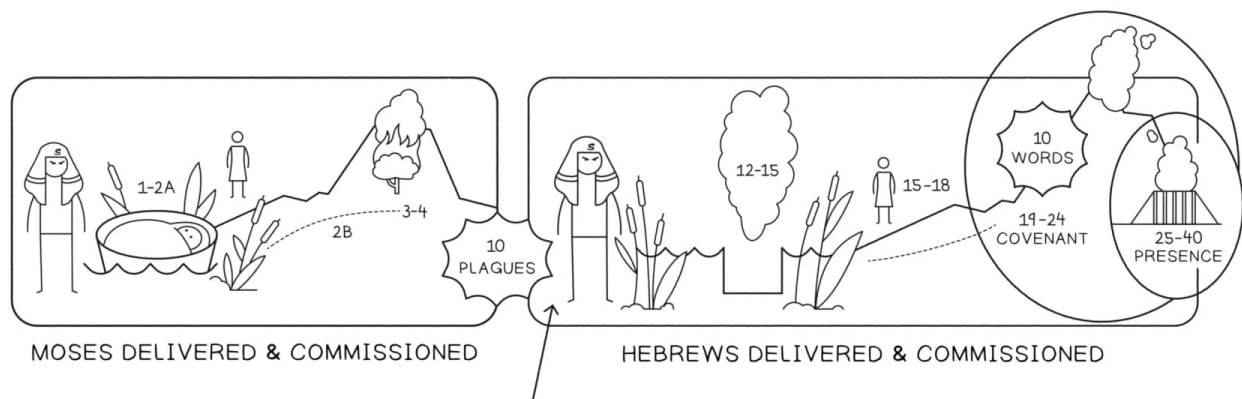
12-15a: Passover and exodus

15b-18: Wilderness journey

19-40: Hebrews commissioned by YHWH

19-24: Covenant

25-40: Presence



Exodus Overview. Illustration created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).

Recommended Resource

[*The Liturgy of Creation: Understanding Calendars in Old Testament Context*](#) by Michael LeFebvre

Reflection Question

In Exodus 1:1-2:10, who is named, who is unnamed, and why?